The Noble Sūtra in Forty-Two Sections

Toh 359 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་དམྱ་བ་ཞུ་གཉིས་པ་ཞེས་བ་བྱའོ་མིད་

The Noble Sūtra Called Forty-Two Sections, known in Tibetan as Phakpa Dumbu Zhenyipa Zhejawé Do, is the Tibetan version of the Chinese Sūtra in Forty-two Sections, and its title line gives the Chinese name in Tibetan transcription instead of a Sanskrit one. The sūtra opens just after the Buddha's awakening, when he turns the wheel of the Dharma of the four truths for the group of five at the Deer Park in Ṛṣipatana. It then gathers a series of short teachings, each introduced with the words "Again the Blessed One declared," that use simple similes to explain renunciation, the dangers of desire, steady and balanced effort on the path, how rare and precious a human birth is, and how brief life is. Its colophon tells the traditional story of how Buddhism first came to China under Emperor Ming of Han, and records that the sūtra, missing from the earlier Tibetan collections, was translated from the Chinese canon by imperial order in the Qing period, together with Manchu and Mongolian versions. It is catalogued as Toh 359 in the Kangyur, where it belongs to the General Sūtra section.

In the language of China: Hpho ba sho za shī i la ṭād kying. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Sūtra Called Forty-Two Sections.

Homage to the Three Jewels.

At that time the Blessed One, having realized unsurpassed awakening, reflected thus: "Freedom from attachment and perfect peace are the most excellent." Abiding in great meditative absorption, he had vanquished all the hosts of Māra, and so, intending now to turn the wheel of Dharma in order to liberate sentient beings, he went to the Deer Park at Ṛṣipatana. There he turned the wheel of the Dharma of the four truths for the group of five, the venerable Ājñāta Kauṇḍinya and the others, and thereby established them in the path and its fruit.

Then other monks came before the Blessed One and asked the Blessed One about the doubts in their own minds. Through the Blessed One's correct teaching they were freed from the doubts in their minds, and, with palms joined toward the Blessed One, they listened respectfully to what the Blessed One taught.

At that time the Blessed One spoke this sacred Dharma called the Forty-Two Sections.

The Blessed One declared: "One who has left his relatives, gone forth from home, and abides in the training, who sees the reality of the mind and realizes the unconditioned dharma, is called an ascetic (śramaṇa). One who abides in all the two hundred and fifty-three precepts without exception, who diligently and with effort accomplishes the path of the four truths and makes himself completely pure, is called an arhat."

Again the Blessed One declared: "An arhat rises into the sky above and displays various miracles and emanations; he is able to shake all the world systems completely, and he is able to sustain his life forces for as long as he wishes. Below him is the non-returner. The non-returner, after passing from this life, is born in the nineteenth abode of the gods, and in that very place attains arhatship. Below him is the once-returner. The once-returner, after passing from this life, is born in a higher realm, then returns once more and attains arhatship. Below him is the stream-enterer. The stream-enterer, after passing from life seven times and taking birth seven times, at the end attains arhatship. Completely abandoning craving for sensual pleasures is like cutting off the limbs of the body completely: afterwards they can never be used again."

Again the Blessed One declared: "Monks who have gone forth, free from craving for sensual pleasures, fully knowing their own minds, realize the meaning of the profound path of the buddhas, the unconditioned. Thereby there is nothing to attain, nothing to seek, nothing to be bound by the path, nothing to be joined by the path, nothing to think, nothing to do, nothing to cultivate, nothing to realize; it abides nowhere at all, and by its very nature it is supreme and most excellent. This is called the path."

Again the Blessed One declared: "Those who have shaved off their hair and beard, become monks, and entered fully into the teaching of the Blessed One should give up the goods of the world and live on alms. They should eat a single meal at midday, make their lodging at the foot of a tree, and, being heedful, should not take food afterwards. Why is that? Because craving for sensual pleasures deludes people."

Again the Blessed One declared: "Sentient beings accomplish virtue in ten ways, and they accomplish non-virtue in ten ways. What are the ten? Three of body, four of speech, and three of mind. What are the three of body? Taking

life, taking what is not given, and sexual misconduct out of desire. What are the four of speech? Telling lies, idle talk, harsh speech, and slander. What are the three of mind? Covetousness, malice, and, through delusion, lacking faith in the Three Jewels and holding wrong views. Lay followers who do not fall back through laziness from the five practices, and who practice virtue in the ten ways, will certainly attain the fruit."

Again the Blessed One declared: "When people commit many wrongs and feel no regret, the fruit of the evil they have gradually accumulated ripens upon themselves, just as rivers, when they flow down into the great ocean, become deep and wide of themselves and hard to cross. When people see their wrongs and restrain themselves from then on, virtuous qualities increase, evil gradually subsides, and the paths are also accomplished."

Again the Blessed One declared: "Even though foolish people commit evil, unwholesome deeds against the Tathāgata, he embraces them with immeasurable love; and though they insult him improperly again and again, he in return protects them with the compassion of immeasurable love and the other immeasurables. On this basis the Tathāgata has gained mastery over the glory of merit and good qualities, while harm and suffering arise for those people.

"Moreover, a certain foolish man heard that the nature of the conduct of the Buddha, the Blessed One, is this very embodiment of love and compassion, so that even when insulted he responds with love. He came before the Blessed One and reviled him, but the Blessed One remained seated without saying anything at all, thinking with great compassion: 'This is a deluded, unclear, foolish person.' When the man had finished reviling him, the Blessed One said: 'Son, if you were to offer hospitality to someone and he did not accept it, what would you do?' The man replied: 'I would take it back.' The Blessed One said: 'Son, the Tathāgata has not accepted the abuse you have just heaped upon him, so carry it back. Suffering will arise for you. Just as an echo follows a sound and a shadow follows a body, you will never be parted from that ripening. Therefore one should put an end to evil, unwholesome deeds.'"

Again the Blessed One declared: "When evil people harm the virtuous, it is like spitting at the sky: the spittle cannot soil the sky, but instead soils oneself. It is also like throwing dust at another against the wind: the dust cannot reach the other person, but instead comes back and sticks to oneself. One should not slander the virtuous, for by doing harm to the virtuous one brings ruin upon

oneself."

Again the Blessed One declared: "Those who train in conduct should strive in love and compassion, and should also give gifts, for the benefits of giving are very great. If one practices the Dharma well with a restrained mind, the merit of that is very great. When one sees another practicing the Dharma, by helping and rejoicing in it one also obtains the ripening of merit."

Someone asked: "Blessed One, in that case, does the heap of merit of the first person not diminish?"

He declared: "Suppose that in a certain place there is a lit torch, and many people from the four directions bring many torches, light them from it, cook their food, and dispel the darkness. Just as that fire is not exhausted, so too that heap of merit is not."

Again the Blessed One declared: "Giving food to a hundred ordinary people does not equal giving food to one virtuous person. Giving food to a thousand virtuous people does not equal giving food to one who keeps the five precepts. Giving food to ten thousand who keep the five precepts does not equal giving food to one stream-enterer. Giving food to a million stream-enterers does not equal giving food to one once-returner. Giving food to ten million once-returners does not equal giving food to one non-returner. Giving food to ten million non-returners does not equal giving food to one arhat. Giving food to a hundred million arhats does not equal giving food to one pratyekabuddha. Giving food to a billion pratyekabuddhas does not equal offering the midday meal to one buddha. Why is that? Because of the wish to seek fully and train in the path of the buddhas, and the wish to accomplish the benefit of all sentient beings. Therefore the heap of merit from offering food to the virtuous is very great.

"Rather than serving the worldly gods, spirits and bhūtas, it is supreme to respect one's father and mother and to honor them, for father and mother are the supreme field of merit."

Again the Blessed One declared: "In the world there are twenty kinds of difficulty. What are they? They are as follows. It is hard for the poor to give gifts. It is hard for the rich and prosperous to train in the path. It is hard to give up one's life with resolve. It is hard to see the scriptures of the sacred Dharma. It is hard to be born in a realm where a buddha has appeared. It is hard to remain unattached to sensual pleasures and to hold firm. It is hard not to long for what is attractive when one sees it. It is hard for the powerful and wealthy

not to fall under the sway of power and wealth. It is hard not to become angry at those who revile one. It is hard not to form intentions when one meets with matters to be done. It is hard to reach the end, even when one has trained much. It is hard not to despise those who are untrained. It is hard to overcome the pride that thinks, 'I am.' It is hard to meet a spiritual friend. It is hard to know the nature of the mind and train in the path. It is hard to remain wholly unmoved when one meets with sense objects. It is hard to act with means suited to people's understanding. It is hard to train beings in accord with their dispositions. It is hard to settle the mind in equanimity. It is hard not to talk about what should and should not be done."

A monk asked the Blessed One: "By what cause does one attain awakening? By what condition does one come to recollect one's former lives?"

The Blessed One declared: "Merely to say that awakening has no characteristics and no signs is of no benefit; what matters is to guard the conduct of the mind. For example, when a mirror is wiped, its rust is cleared away and it becomes clear and bright, so that reflections appear in it clearly. In the same way, by completely abandoning desire and constantly practicing the dharma of emptiness, one attains the noble path, correctly, just as it is, and also comes to recollect one's former lives."

Again the Blessed One declared: "What is the supreme virtue? Practicing the path is itself the supreme virtue. What is the supreme greatness? Bringing the mind into accord with the Dharma is the supreme greatness. What is supreme among those endowed with strength? It is patience, for one endowed with patience does no evil deeds, and so will certainly be honored by people. What is supreme clarity? That which is without obscuration and free of stains, without misconduct and completely pure; one who has not even the slightest thing, among all that exists in the worlds of the ten directions from beginningless time until now, that he does not know, does not see, does not fully understand, or does not hear, and who is endowed with the wisdom of omniscience: that is called clarity."

Again the Blessed One declared: "Because sentient beings are obscured by a mind filled with attachment, they do not see the path correctly, just as it is. For example, if five kinds of dye are put into muddy water and stirred with all one's strength, people who look into it cannot see the reflection of their own bodies. In the same way, because the mind is made turbid by the confusion of attachment, one does not see the path. But when people, with devotion,

gradually confess and restrain their faults and please a spiritual friend, then, just as the muddy impurities of the water clear and reflections become clear, they will see the path.

"Again, for example, suppose flames are spread beneath a copper cauldron, so that the water inside boils fiercely, and it is covered over with cloth. When people come up to the cauldron and look, they do not see their own reflections. In the same way, because the mind stream is stirred up by the three poisons that have dwelt in it since beginningless time and is covered by the five obscurations, one cannot see the path. When the stains of the mind are entirely exhausted, one knows from where consciousness has come and been born, and into which buddha fields it will go after dying and passing on, and one also sees the qualities of the path."

Again the Blessed One declared: "One who trains in conduct is like someone who enters a dark house holding a lamp in his hand: the darkness is dispelled and there is only light. When one has trained in the path and sees the truth, the darkness of delusion and bewilderment is cleared away, so that there is nothing that is not clear."

Again the Blessed One declared: "Whatever the Tathāgata thinks of, he thinks of the path. Whatever he does, he does the path. Whatever he says, he speaks the path. Through mindfulness, the Tathāgata never forgets the true path."

Again the Blessed One declared: "When you see the sky and the earth, you should think, 'This is impermanent.' When you see mountains and valleys, you should think, 'This is impermanent.' When you see the shapes and forms of things growing and expanding, you should think, 'This too is impermanent.' By thinking in this way, before long you will attain the paths."

Again the Blessed One declared: "Day after day, continually, one should think of the path and practice it. By that one gains the faculty of faith, and so the kinds of merit are immeasurable."

Again the Blessed One declared: "Although the conventional term 'self' is applied to the great elements of the body, they are without self. The self is merely temporary and does not abide permanently; it is like an illusion."

Again the Blessed One declared: "Sentient beings who follow desire and pursue fame are like incense that is burned. Although others smell its fragrance, the incense, burned throughout, cannot escape being entirely consumed. In the same way, fools who are attached to the renown of the

ordinary world and do not strive for the true renown of the truth are left deprived of fame and gain, and regret arises in them."

Again the Blessed One declared: "Form and wealth are like honey smeared on the edge of a knife: when small children merely taste it, the suffering of a cut tongue arises."

Again the Blessed One declared: "The danger for sentient beings who are bound by children, wife, wealth and home is greater than the danger of the stocks, iron chains and the like for a man thrown into prison. From the danger of prison, release may come by chance. But attachment to children, wife and the rest carries a danger like being caught in a tiger's mouth, and yet fools enter into it heedlessly, and so they cannot be freed from it."

Again the Blessed One declared: "Among attachments to the pleasures of the senses, attachment to form surpasses all other attachments; there is no attachment greater than attachment to form. Fortunately, desire and attachment for form is only one. If a second like it existed, there would be no one in the world able to train in the path."

Again the Blessed One declared: "Engaging in objects of desire is like a fool who holds a torch in his hand and walks against the wind: if he does not throw the torch away, the harm of burning his hand will certainly befall him. If attachment, aversion and delusion, the three present in the mind stream, are not first removed by the path, the danger is great, like that of fools who do not let go of the torch in their hand and so burn their hands."

Then, in order to test him, a god sent a divine maiden before the Blessed One. The Blessed One said to her: "You leather bag full of all kinds of filth, why have you come? You may be able to deceive ordinary people, but how could you move in any way the Tathāgata, who possesses the six superknowledges? The Tathāgata has no need of you. Go!"

Then that goddess gained deep faith in the Blessed One and asked about the doubts in her mind, and the Blessed One, explaining them in detail, established her in the fruit of stream-entry.

Again the Blessed One declared: "When people train in the path, they are like a log floating on the surface of the water. If that log, carried along with the current, touches neither the far bank nor the near bank, is not taken by people, is not turned back by gods or spirits, is not caught in a whirlpool, and does not rot, I say that it will certainly flow down into the great ocean. In the

same way, if people, when they train in the path, are not deluded by attachment, are not seized by distorted views, do not waver, and exert themselves with effort, I say that those people will certainly attain the path."

Again the Blessed One declared: "Ascetics, do not trust your minds! Never put your trust in the mind. Be heedful! Do not be attached to forms, for attachment to forms gives rise to suffering. Only when you have realized arhatship is it fitting to trust your minds."

Then the Blessed One again declared to the ascetics: "Ascetics, be heedful! You should not look at women. Even if you meet them, you should not look at them; be careful and do not converse with them. If you do converse, think: 'I am an ascetic. I should live in this degenerate world like a lotus unsoiled by mud.' Toward old women generate the perception of a mother, toward those a little older than yourself the perception of an elder sister, and toward those younger than yourself the perception of a younger sister; and do not treat the young improperly with contempt.

"If improper attention arises, you should examine and investigate it carefully. You should examine it in this way: examine the body from the crown of the head to the soles of the feet. Then examine the inside of the body, thinking: 'The inside of the body is entirely filled with all kinds of impurities, which are oozing out.' In this way you should completely dispel that improper attention."

Again the Blessed One declared: "Just as, when fire spreads through dry grass, one must quickly get away from it, so people who train in the path should cast objects of desire far away."

Again the Blessed One declared: "A certain man, tormented in mind by desire and finding no means to calm that lustful mind, cut off his own organ with an axe. The Blessed One said this to him: 'Rather than cutting off your organ, it is far better to cut off the mind.'"

"The mind is the chief. When the chief is cut off, the retinue ceases of its own accord. If you do not cut off the perverted mind, what use is there in cutting off the organ?" So he spoke. Then that man died. The Blessed One declared: "Worldly people who hold wrong views are fools just like this deluded man."

Again, a young woman had arranged to meet a man, but the man did not arrive at the appointed time. The young woman, filled with regret, spoke this verse:

"Desire, I know your root:
You arise from conceptual thought.
When I no longer think of you,
You will never arise again."

So she spoke. At that time the Blessed One, who was passing along that road, heard it, and said to the śramaṇas: "Śramaṇas, keep this in mind! This verse was spoken by the Blessed One, the Buddha Kāśyapa, and it is renowned and handed down continuously in the world."

Again the Blessed One declared: "Because sentient beings are attached to the objects of sense pleasure, suffering arises, and from suffering, fear arises. Without attachment, suffering does not arise; and without suffering, fear does not arise."

Again the Blessed One declared: "When people train in the path, it is like one man doing battle with many tens of thousands of men. For example, a man puts on armor, takes up weapons, and sets out; then one turns back out of fear, or one turns back halfway along the road, or one is killed in the fighting, or one is victorious, returns to his own land, and becomes a leader. In the same way, if with a mind that is utterly firm one strives and exerts oneself in practice and is not deceived by delusion, one will certainly abandon desire and attain the fruit."

At that time a certain śramaṇa, while reciting at night, was worn out by reciting in a loud voice and at great speed; he became regretful and began to think, "I will go back down to the household life." Then the Blessed One summoned him and declared: "When you lived in the household before, what work did you do?"

He replied, "I worked at playing the vīṇā."

The Blessed One declared, "What happens if the strings are slack?"

He replied, "No sound comes out."

"What happens if the strings are tight?"

"The sound breaks off."

"What happens if the strings are set just right?"

"Then the strings are neither too high nor too low, and the sound is even."

Then the Blessed One declared to that śramaṇa: "So too, when training in the path, it is by restraining the mind in just such an even way that one attains the

path."

Again the Blessed One declared: "Training in the path is like this. For example, when iron is smelted and refined, and is gradually hammered so that its dross is cleansed away, then whatever vessel one makes from it, it becomes workable. Just so, when those who train in the path gradually purify the stains of the mind and diligently train toward awakening, they will without doubt accomplish awakening. Otherwise one becomes weary oneself; through weariness one becomes afflicted; through being thoroughly afflicted one turns back from the path; and having turned back from the path, one accumulates evil karma."

Again the Blessed One declared: "For people, practicing the path is suffering, and not practicing the path is also suffering. The suffering that sentient beings undergo from birth until old age, and from old age until sickness and death, is hard to measure. Because the mind is stirred up by afflictions and evil karma is accumulated, birth and death arise one after another, and so the suffering can never be fully told."

Again the Blessed One declared: "It is hard for sentient beings to be freed from the lower realms and obtain the support of a human body. Even having obtained the support of a human body, it is hard to turn away from the support of a woman's body and obtain the state of a man. Even having obtained the support of a man's body, it is hard to have all the faculties complete. Even with all the faculties complete, it is hard to be born in the central land. Even being born in the central land, it is hard to train in accordance with the Buddha's teaching. Even training in accordance with the Buddha's teaching, it is hard to meet a king who upholds the Dharma. Even meeting a king who upholds the Dharma, it is hard to be born in the family of a bodhisattva. And even being born in the family of a bodhisattva, it is hard to have faith in the Three Jewels and to be born in a world-system where a buddha dwells."

Again the Blessed One declared to the śramaṇas: "How long does a person's life last?"

One śramaṇa replied, "It lasts about ten days."

The Blessed One declared, "My son, you have not yet trained in the path."

Again he declared to another śramaṇa: "How long does a person's life last?"

He replied, "About the space of a meal."

The Blessed One declared, "Go! You too have not trained in the path."

Again he declared to another śramaṇa: "How long does a person's life last?"

He replied, "It lasts about the space of a single breath going out and coming in."

Then the Blessed One said, "Excellent! Therefore it can be said, my son, that you have trained in the path."

Again the Blessed One declared: "Even if śrāvakas go a thousand leagues away from the Tathāgata, if they keep in mind the training of the Blessed One's Vinaya, they will without doubt attain the fruit. But even if one dwells in the presence of the Teacher, if one attends to what is meaningless, one will never attain the fruit of the path. The crux of it depends on practice: even if one dwells near the Teacher, if one does not train oneself, one will not find even the slightest benefit."

Again the Blessed One declared: "For people, practicing the path is like honey: at the edges and in the middle, it is sweet throughout. The Buddha's Dharma too is just like this: it is endowed throughout with the meaning of joy and happiness, and by practicing it one attains the path."

Again the Blessed One declared: "For people, by practicing the path, desire is pulled out by its roots altogether. For example, just as when one takes the beads one by one from a rosary hung up in the air, the rosary is gradually used up, so too all obscurations are gradually exhausted, and one attains the fruit of the path."

Again the Blessed One declared: "When śramaṇas train in the path, let them be like a laden ox in deep mud: however weary it becomes, it has no thought of going to either bank to rest. A śramaṇa should regard desire as far more dreadful even than the danger of such mud, and by pressing on single-mindedly along the path with an upright mind, should save himself from the suffering of saṃsāra."

Again the Blessed One declared: "The Tathāgata sees all the splendid wealth of kings and ministers as spittle and ashes. He sees gold, silver and other precious things as gravel and potsherds. He sees silk and other costly garments as rags. He sees the great trichiliocosm, the world-system of a thousand million worlds, as a single myrobalan fruit. He sees the waters of the four great oceans as oil rubbed on the soles of the feet. He sees the gateways of skillful means as a ship filled with jewels. He sees the Great Vehicle as gold and silk in a dream. He sees the search for the path of the buddhas as flowers

before the eyes. He sees the search for meditative absorption as a pillar as firm as Mount Meru. He sees the search for complete nirvāṇa as being awake throughout the day and night. He sees what is true and what is untrue as the dance of six nāgas. He sees equanimity as truth itself. He sees flourishing and decline as a tree through the four seasons."

Thus the Blessed One declared, and all the monks of the assembly rejoiced and highly praised what the Blessed One had said.

Now, in the twenty-fourth year of King Zhao of Zhou, a Wood Male Tiger year, on the eighth day of the fourth month, a mass of light appeared at the palace from the southwest. When the king asked the ministers who knew the meaning of omens, they foretold that it was a sign that a great being had arisen in that direction, and that after a thousand years his teaching would spread in this land. Then, in the fifty-third year of King Mu, a Water Male Monkey year, on the fifteenth day of the second month, the Teacher displayed the manner of passing into nirvāṇa.

Then, in the one thousand and thirteenth year after that, in the seventh year of the Yongping era of Emperor Ming of Han, on the night of the fifteenth day of the first month, there appeared in the king's dream a great person, more than two fathoms in height, golden in color and radiating light like the light of the sun, who descended to the palace and said, "My teaching will gradually spread in this land." The next day, when he asked his ministers, the minister called Fu Yi replied, "Long ago, in the time of King Zhao of Zhou, a prophecy was made, and it accords with the king's dream." Then the king had the old records read, and when he found that prophecy from the time of King Zhao of Zhou, he rejoiced. The king dispatched eighteen men, the minister Wang Zun and others, and sent them to the west to seek the teaching of the Buddha.

When they arrived in the kingdom called Yāshi, at that same time two men were coming from India: the arhat Mātaṅga, of the Kāśyapa clan, and the paṇḍita Gobharaṇa. On a white horse they carried a painted scroll of the Teacher, the sūtras of the Great and Lesser Vehicles, among them the scripture the Sūtra in Forty-two Sections, and a vase filled with the Teacher's relics. The two parties met on the road, and on the last day of the twelfth month of the tenth year of Yongping they arrived at the city of Luoyang.

Then, six years later, the arhat and the paṇḍita subdued the Bön priests of China. Then the arhat and the paṇḍita rose up into the sky and spoke this verse to the king:

"The fox is not of the lion's lineage;
A lamp does not shine like the sun and moon;
A pond cannot hold the ocean;
A hillock is not as beautiful as Mount Meru.
The clouds of the Dharma pervade the whole world;
The rain of the Dharma moistens the sprouts in the minds of beings;
They openly display marvelous miraculous powers,
And tame beings in all directions."

Having spoken thus, they went to India by miraculous power.

This sūtra, possessed of such a provenance, had not previously been translated in Tibet, but was contained in the Chinese Kangyur. By order of the Qianlong Emperor it was translated into the Manchu language, and into the Tibetan language it was translated by the two Kachu masters Subhagśreyaṅdhvaja and Dhyānāriṣṭaṃbyās. Into the Mongolian language it was translated by the Rabjampa Prajñodayabyāsa.

The patron Hing Lin, who has exceptional faith in the teaching of the Victor, in order to spread the gift of the Dharma far and wide, had printing blocks carved, with a hundred silver taels, setting the four languages side by side; and having printed as many copies as he could, he offered them to those who are supreme and holy fields of merit. By this root of virtue, may the precious teaching of the Victor flourish, spread and long endure; may disease, famine, strife and conflict never arise in the world-systems; and may all sentient beings, our mothers, swiftly attain unsurpassed great awakening.

sarba maṅgalaṃ

Here begins volume Ka of the Collected Tantras.

Translator's Notes

• This sūtra is a Tibetan translation from Chinese; the title "in the language of China" is a Tibetan transcription, given here as spelled, of the Chinese Fo shuo sishi'er zhang jing, the Sūtra of Forty-Two Sections Spoken by the Buddha. In the opening, "bdud ste" is read as "bdud sde," the hosts of Māra, and "du ma bu" in the title of the teaching as "dum bu," sections. In the third section the Tibetan reads "conditioned" (‘dus byas), which contradicts what follows; it is read as "the unconditioned" (‘dus ma byas), in agreement with the Chinese parallel.
• In the passage on attachment the Tibetan reads "tha ma" ("the last"), which makes no sense in context; it is read as "lam" ("the path"), which the following sentences repeatedly name and which the Chinese parallel has. The twelfth difficulty is terse in the Tibetan (literally "untrained, not despising self"); it is rendered after the evident sense, which the Chinese parallel gives as "not slighting the untrained."

• Several evident scribal slips are read by their sense: "slob dpon" (teacher) at the start as "slob pa" (one who trains); "mdzad" in the incense simile as "zad" (consumed); and "rgyal ba" (victor) in the Buddha's address to the divine maiden as "rkyal pa" (leather bag), which the Chinese parallel confirms. The word rendered "elder sister" (a phyi) usually means "grandmother," but the context of "a little older than yourself" and the Chinese parallel require "elder sister." In the final section "mtshan ma" denotes the sexual organ.
• This sūtra is a translation from the Chinese Sūtra in Forty-two Sections. The recurring phrase written □□□□ (as in □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ and □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□) makes no sense as written and is read as □□□□, "the path", which the context and the Chinese parallel both require. □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is read as □□□□□□□, "through weariness", and □□□□□□ as □□□□□□, "evil". The answer about life lasting "the space of a meal" takes □□□□□ as food or a meal, which matches the Chinese. In the vīṇā dialogue □□□□□ means the strings of the instrument. In the ox simile, "going to either bank to rest" follows the Tibetan; the Chinese has the ox not looking to left or right until it is out of the mud.
• The closing similes follow the last section of the Chinese Sūtra in Forty-two Sections, though the Tibetan departs from the Chinese in places (for instance "spittle and ashes" for the rank of kings, and "a ship filled with jewels" for skillful means); the translation follows the Tibetan. The Chinese names are transcribed in the Tibetan: □□□□□□□□□□□□ is King Zhao of Zhou, □□□□□ is King Mu, □□□□□□□□□□□ is Emperor Ming of Han, □□□□□□□ is the Yongping era, □□□□□□ is Fu Yi, □□□□□□ is Wang Zun, and □□□□□□□ is Luoyang. The later □□□□□□□ is taken to be the same Yongping era. □□□□□ is probably the land of the Yuezhi, but it is kept in the form the Tibetan gives. The "Bön priests of China" are presumably the Daoist masters of the Chinese account. □□□□□□□□□ is read as □□□□□□□□, and □□□ as □□, "printing blocks". The names of the Tibetan and Mongolian translators are Sanskritized religious names; they are romanized as the Tibetan spells them, because the intended Sanskrit forms are uncertain. Kachu (bka' bcu) and Rabjampa are scholastic titles. The final line is the heading of the next volume, which follows in the print.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.